Step Six of Nine: Where Preparing Dad's Finances for Future Care Sits, and Who Is Involved

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

You've been thinking about how Dad's care would be paid for someday. The money questions can feel like the whole subject. They are one step among nine, with steps before them and steps after.

This page shows the whole road, where the financial step sits on it, and who is involved.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1 **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
You finish with: Future Care Planning Assessment

2 **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
You finish with: Family Financial Inventory

3 **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4 **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
You finish with: Advance Medicaid Planning Roadmap

5 **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
You finish with: Legal Planning Review

6 **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
You finish with: Long-Term Care Funding Plan

You are here. This step is about how Dad's care could be paid for if he ever needs it: what could help, which financial questions could matter for Medicaid later, and what to raise with the right professionals. It is finished when the family understands how future care could be funded, which financial issues could affect Medicaid, and which strategies to raise with the right professionals, while no decision has to be made.

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7 **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
You finish with: Medicaid Application-Ready File

8 **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
You finish with: Asset Protection Assessment

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System
You finish with: Medicaid Monitoring & Maintenance System

What comes before it

Five steps sit ahead of this one. In the first phase a family understands the care picture, organizes the income, assets and expenses into a financial file, and assesses where things stand. Then come the written plan and the legal step. The financial step draws on all of that, the financial file most of all.

If this is the first page you've come to, nothing is out of order. A dated list of what Dad has is a fair place to begin, and it serves the earlier steps too.

What this step produces

A Long-Term Care Funding Plan. It runs from costs and how long resources could last, through how assets may be treated and the tools Dad already has, to a strategy that is written down. The family's part is the list of what exists, the policies and benefits nobody has checked, and the questions. The projections and the strategy are worked through with professionals. The plan isn't proof of eligibility or a guarantee that anything is protected.

What happens next

Your Medicaid planner reviews how different assets may be treated for Medicaid purposes and which financial issues could matter later, and coordinates the financial side with legal planning by an elder law attorney, and with a licensed insurance professional or a licensed financial professional for any insurance or financial tool. The federal Administration for Community Living lists exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid among the things elder law attorneys do. [1]

After this comes the third phase: Apply, Protect and Maintain. For a family planning ahead, those steps may be a long way off. The Administration for Community Living says the best time to apply for Medicaid depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of their finances, which is one reason this page gives no dates. [2]

This step also comes around again. Your Medicaid planner helps the family decide when to review the funding plan, including after major changes in health, finances, marital status or care needs.

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: listing what Dad has, finding the paperwork, keeping the list of questions.
- Dad: his money, his policies and his decisions. He takes part in all of it.
- Your Medicaid planner: reviews how different assets may be treated for Medicaid purposes, coordinates with the other professionals, and helps the family decide when to look at the plan again.
- An elder law attorney: legal planning, legal advice and legal documents.
- A licensed insurance professional or a licensed financial professional: any insurance or financial tool, and the questions about the policies Dad already has.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. Families move through the steps at different speeds, and rules vary by state. Nothing on this page is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know where the financial step sits, what comes before it and who is involved after it. The planning interview is the next thing to do from here: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The description of what elder law attorneys do, and the statement about the best time to apply, come from the Administration for Community Living.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid